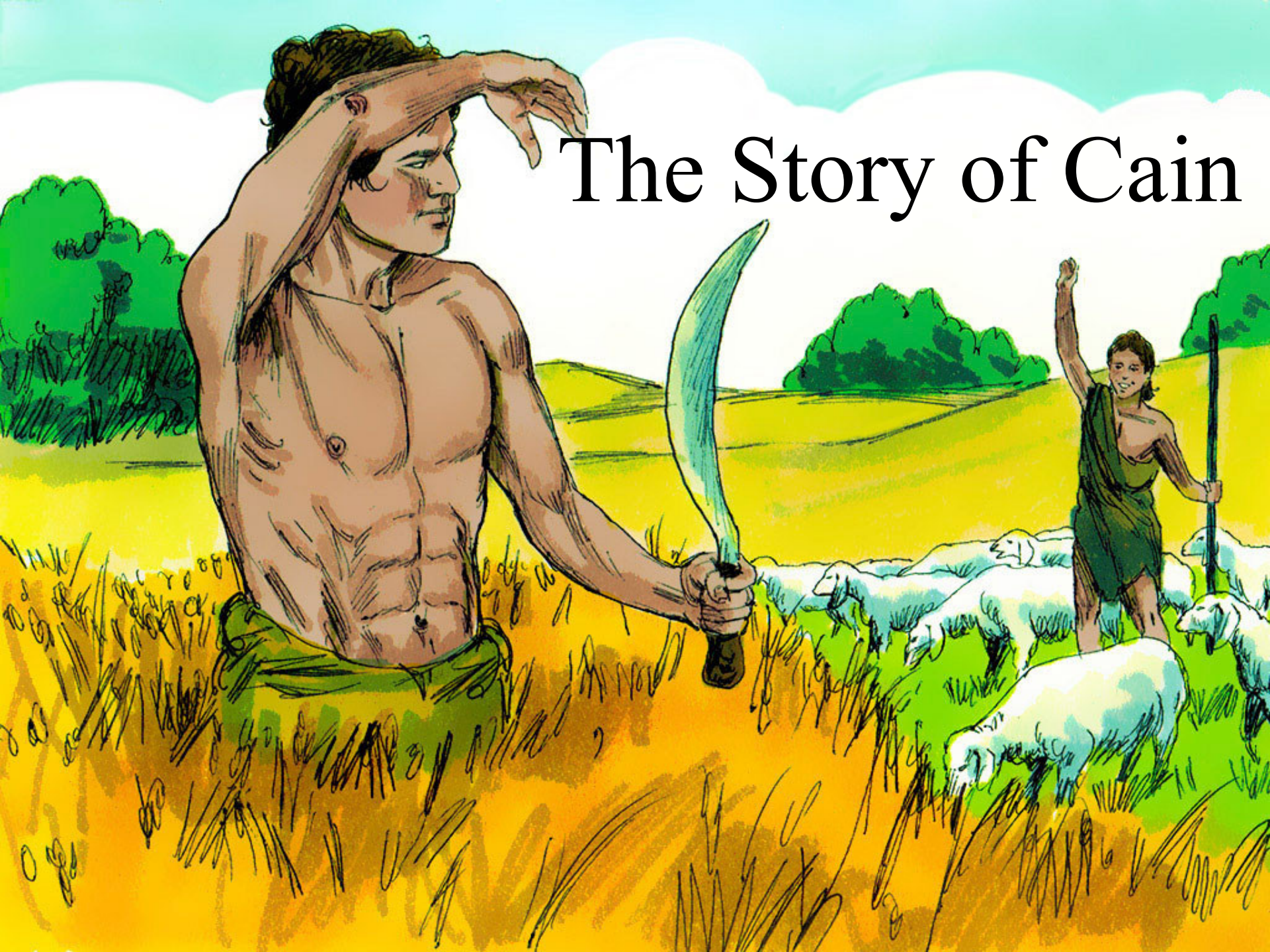
The Story of Cain



The Story of Cain

"This is what happened to the earth and the heavens"

Part II

The Story of Cain

- The story of Cain continues the Eden narrative by . . .
  - using similar structure and literary devices
    - principal characters and their functions.
    - warning and judgment by God
    - movement eastward, etc.
  - developing its content

The Story of Cain

- The Eden narrative:
  - What happened to God's work in the hands of humanity
- The Story of Cain:
  - What happened to humanity
    - focused on self-interest and preservation
    - lack of faith in God leading to disobedience
    - disharmony within humanity
    - loss of vitality

The Story of Cain

The technique of one narrative developing secondary themes of the previous narrative seems to be a major literary device used in Genesis 1—11.

The Story of Cain

Progressive Development of Themes

- The ***creation account's primary*** theme is God's creative work turning death into life and vitality.
- The ***creation account's secondary*** theme is the tension of what happens to the creation in the hands of humanity.

The Story of Cain

Progressive Development of Themes (con't)

- The ***Eden narrative*** takes up the ***secondary*** theme of the ***creation account*** *(creation in the hands of humanity)* . . .

  and develops it as its own ***primary*** theme *(devastation of creation thru seizure of autonomy)*.
- The ***Eden narrative***, in turn, introduces its own ***secondary*** themes *(loss of unity, loss of blessing, and disobedience due to lack of faith)*.

The Story of Cain

Progressive Development of Themes (con't)

- The ***Story of Cain*** takes up the ***secondary*** themes of the Eden narrative *(loss of unity, loss of blessing, disobedience due to lack of faith)* . . . and develops them as its own ***primary*** theme.
- ***Genesis 5—11*** then takes up the ***secondary*** themes of the story of Cain *(self-destructive effects)* and develops them as its ***primary*** theme.

The Story of Cain

Progressive Development of Themes (con't)

This progressive development is more than simply a literary device . . .

***it implies a hierarchy of priority*.**

The Story of Cain

Hierarchy of Priority

- The primary concerns of the Cain story (i.e., the secondary themes of the Eden narrative) must be understood ***within the context*** of the primary subject matter of the Eden narrative.
- That is, loss of unity, blessing thru disobedience and lack of faith is ***secondary*** to effects on creation of humanity's seizure of autonomy.
  - ***personal consequences are secondary to actions***

The Story of Cain

Hierarchy of Priority (con't)

- The primary concerns of the Eden narrative (i.e., the secondary theme of the creation account) must be understood ***within the context*** of the primary subject matter of the creation account.
- That is, the effect of humanity's seizure of autonomy must be understood as secondary to God's creative work.
  - ***man's actions are secondary to God's purpose and work***

The Story of Cain

Hierarchy of Priority (con't)

- Thus . . .
  - The dominating theme is God's creative purposes and work.
  - Subsumed under this theme is what humanity has done with that work.
  - Subordinated to what humanity has ***done*** is human motivation and self-destruction.

The Story of Cain

Preliminary Issues

- The nature of Cain's sacrifice
- Relationship to the Eden Narrative
- Name of God
- Where did the idea of sacrifice come from?

Cain's Sacrifice

- Was something wrong with Cain's sacrifice?
- Why did God accept Abel's sacrifice and reject Cain's?
- Do the answers to these questions *even matter* in the story?

Cain's Sacrifice

Characterized as Negative

- Presented in ***contrast*** to Abel's.
  - "Cain brought . . . ***but*** Abel brought"
  - "The Lord looked upon Abel and his offering ***but*** upon Cain and his offering he did not look"
- Negative rhetorical characterization: "fruit of the ground"
  - Previously, "fruit" was usually associated with trees.
  - Only connection of fruit with the ground was with ***"the earth"*** (*eretz*).
  - With Cain, it is fruit of ***"the ground"*** (*adamah*)
  - "The ground" was what the man was condemned to work for food and to which he would return.
  - Therefore, ***Cain's work is associated with the curse***.
- Abel brought "firstfruits," but not Cain.
- God's speech: "If you do what is right . . ."

Cain's Sacrifice

- Clearly presented in a negative light
- Related to his inner motivation
  - "firstfruits,"
  - "do what is right"
- Does it matter?
  - No direct evaluation by the narrator . . .
  - and apart from any explicit reference by God . . .
  - implies that the reader should understand it in a negative light but NOT consider it part of the main storyline.
  - It is background information only
- *The issue is Cain's reaction to God's correction!*

Relationship to Eden Narrative

- Begins with the Eden characters
  - "the man"
  - "Eve, his wife" *("the mother of all living")*
- Ends with the Eden characters
  - "Adam"
  - "his wife"
- Therefore, it is still about what happened in Eden

Name of God

- Creation:
  - “Elohim” > transcendence
- Eden Narrative:
  - “Yahweh Elohim” > transcendence & immanence
- Cain Story:
  - “Yahweh” > just immanence
  - This story focuses on relationship

Sacrifices

- Where did this idea come from?
  - Must be understood contextually.
  - Must be understood in context of the Eden Narrative
- Context
  - banished from paradise
  - doomed to death
  - strained relationship with God
  - shame covered with animal skins

Sacrifices

- Hebrew for “sacrifice” - *minkhah*
  - Not “sacrifice”
  - Rather, “gift”
  - Therefore, they are bringing gifts to God
- Purpose of the gifts?
  - Contextually, probably desiring greater fellowship with God
- Character of gifts?
  - One approaches offering a reminder of God’s provision
  - The other approaches God offering his own works acquired from the curse
- Contrast: God’s provision vs. works

Now the man knew Eve, his wife.

And she became pregnant.

And she bore Cain.

And she said:

"I have created a man with the Lord."

*Now **the man** knew **Eve**, his wife.*

And she became pregnant.

And she bore Cain.

And she said:

"I have created a man with the Lord."

- Why not "the woman"?
- Reference is to "the mother of all living"
- Focuses on the hope for future life

Now the man knew Eve, his wife.

And she became pregnant.

And she bore Cain.

And she said:

*"I have **created** a man **with** the Lord."*

- *Not "I have gotten a man from the Lord"*
- Hebrew verb: *kanah*
  - to purchase
  - to create
  - context requires "create"
- Hebrew preposition: "in," "with," not "from"

Now the man knew Eve, his wife.

And she became pregnant.

And she bore Cain.

*And **she said**:*

"I have created a man with the Lord."

- The woman's perspective
- looking for a replacement for the dying man
- She and the Lord together created the new man

And again, she bore his brother, Abel.
And Abel was a caretaker of sheep,
but Cain, he was a server of the ground.

*And again, she bore **his brother**, Abel.*
And Abel was a caretaker of sheep,
but Cain, he was a server of the ground.

- She bore "his brother"
- Abel's introduction
  - not as a distinct person, but as one associated with the main character
  - the focus on the relationship, Cain's ***brother***

And again, she bore his brother, Abel.

And Abel was a caretaker of sheep,

but *Cain, he was a server of the ground.*

- Presents a contrast of service
  - Abel cares for animals (original creational purpose)
  - Cain serves the ground (result of the curse)

And it happened after some time.

And Cain brought a gift to the Lord from the fruit of the ground.

But Abel, he brought, even he, from the firstborn of his flock and their fat.

And the Lord paid attention to Abel and his gift.

But to Cain and his gift he did not pay attention.

And it happened after some time.

And Cain brought a gift to the Lord from the fruit of the ground.

But Abel, he brought, even he, from the firstborn of his flock and their fat.

*And the Lord paid attention **to Abel** and his gift.*

*But **to Cain** and his gift he did not pay attention.*

- The issue is acceptance of the person

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And Cain brought a gift to the Lord from the fruit of the ground.

But Abel, he brought, even he, from the firstborn of his flock and their fat.

And the Lord paid attention to Abel and ***his gift****.*

But to Cain and ***his gift*** *he did not pay attention.*

- Acceptance of person is based on the mode of approach
- God's provision vs human works

And Cain was very angry.
And his face fell.
And the Lord said to Cain:
"Why are you angry?
And why is your face fallen?
Is it not that, if you do well, there will be a lifting up?
But if you don't do well,
sin is lying at the opening
and to you its desire.
But you will rule over it."

*And Cain was **very** angry.*
And his face fell.
And the Lord said to Cain:
"Why are you angry?
And why is your face fallen?
Is it not that, if you do well, there will be a lifting up?
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- Cain was not just irritated, he was enraged
- But at what?
  - hard work rejected?
  - Abel?
  - God?

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- The topic God addresses . . .
  - Not the sacrifice . . .
  - but Cain's reaction.

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- The question implies that Cain knows what to do
- God encourages Cain to "be happy" as a result of doing right

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- God warns Cain of the consequences of continuing to not do the right thing
- Note:
  - God is pleading with Cain
  - God's concern is Cain's well-being and happiness

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But you will rule over it."

- Hebrew:
  - "lying," not "crouching" *(as a lion for prey)*
  - commonly use of "resting"
- Imagery:
  - animal resting at the tent door waiting to come in
- Sin is waiting to find access

And Cain was very angry.
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"Why are you angry?
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But you will rule over it."

“You will rule over it.”

- Hebrew
  - “rule” – *mashal*, used for ruling one’s spirit in Ps 19:14 and Prov 16:32
  - “will” vs. “must” –
    - Verb form indicates fact *(indicative)* rather than need or desire *(subjunctive)*
    - Same form used in 3:16, “He will rule over you.”
      - Therefore, to be consistent, the parallel statement regarding Cain and the woman must be either

        Woman: *He will rule over you.*

        Cain: *You will rule over it.*

        or

        Woman: *He must rule over you.*

        Cain: *You must rule over it.*

“You will rule over it.”

A Paraphrase

“Why are you angry?
And why is your face fallen?
If you do well, won’t you be happy and content?
But if you don’t do well, sin is lying at the door,
waiting to get you.
But it’s your decision.”

“You will rule over it.”

But what is the “doing well”??